with professional players. It opened my eyes. We'd watch the first team most days and, one time, we went out and were introduced to Mr Venables and the players. Of course, I'm quite good friends with Mark Hughes now. He often laughs about that time in Spain: the Barcelona players didn't have a clue who we were. I still have the photo of me, Mark, Terry Venables and Gary Lineker that was taken that afternoon.

It was an exciting time. I was training with Spurs, and United had let me know they were more than just interested. I went up to Manchester a few times in the school vacations, always with Malcolm Fidgeon in that brown Sierra, and hooked up with the team when they came down to London to play. The club in general, and Alex Ferguson in particular, did their best to make me feel a part of it all. The older players, like Bryan Robson and Steve Bruce, mocked me about those times once I eventually joined the club. I was at pre-match meals and I'd be in the dressing room after games, helping clear away all the uniforms. One afternoon, when United were away to West Ham, they invited me to come along as the mascot. I was given a United tracksuit and there I was, at Upton Park, warming up on the field with the likes of Bryan Robson and Gordon Strachan. Then they let me sit on the bench for the game. I even spotted myself on *Match of the Day* that evening.

United seemed pretty keen on me. Of course, I was so keen on United that it was almost embarrassing. I used to wear my hair spiky, wanting it to look like Gordon Strachan's, and the day of that West Ham game I took him a tub of hair gel as a present. He got some grief about that; and so did I a year or two later. Another time before a game in London, they invited me and Mum and Dad to have an evening meal with the squad at the team hotel at West Lodge Park. Never mind that I ordered a steak and then couldn't understand when a piece of tuna was put down in front of me. I was seated on the top table with the manager and the staff. They had a present for me: one of those padded bench coats. It was about six sizes too big for me. You couldn't see my hands at the ends of the sleeves and it trailed round my ankles, but I didn't take the thing off for a week. Better still, I had a present for the boss: a pen. Alex Ferguson took it and looked at me:

'Thanks, David. I'll tell you what: I'll sign you for Manchester United using this pen'.

Remembering that, it might seem strange that there was ever any doubt about who I was going to sign schoolboy forms with before I turned thirteen. But I'd been really happy training at Spurs and got on well with their Youth Development Officer, John Moncur. It was also important that White Hart